

SIPRA DAS



Back in the Running

PATNA Believe it or not, the good old Ambassador car is back in the reckoning in Bihar because a number of ministers want to dump their swanky sedans in favour of the old matrons.

While many ministers have cited "overall discomfort" as the reason behind their dislike for the luxury cars, according to Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Modi, the obvious contempt that a common man has for the upmarket

cars and those who travel in it has made the worldly-wise ministers prefer Ambassadors, which can also carry more people.

Both Modi and Chief Minister Nitish Kumar prefer travelling in Ambassadors. The issue was taken up after state Water Resources Minister Ramashray Prasad Singh, who had also been provided a sedan, shot off a written complaint about his "troublesome" four-

TRIED AND TRUSTED: The Ambassador

wheeler. "The car provided to me was always developing snags. I am convinced the sturdy Ambassadors are definitely better," the minister said.

The Ambassador, with its rounded contours and distinct humped shape, has been an icon on the dusty roads of India since 1957. Although newer and nimbler cars overshadowed it after restrictions on foreign manufacturers were lifted in 1991, not all are impressed with the glitz.

In 2006, the state Government had purchased 56 luxury cars for Rs 3 crore, aiming for a "new look". These vehicles were provided to all the 28 ministers. Now they are likely to be given to senior bureaucrats and other eligible officers while the ministers would be provided brand new Ambassadors, of which 100 have already been ordered.

by Amitabh Srivastava

Wave of Accidents

DELHI Two unrelated accidents onboard two frontline naval vessels in less than a month have raised questions about safety on Indian warships. The first mishap occurred aboard *INS Jalashwa* (the ex-USS *Trenton*) during recent manoeuvres in the Bay of Bengal—five sailors died after inhaling hydrogen sulphide fumes which had leaked from the ship's sewage treatment plant.



BAD OMEN: *Jalashwa*

Three personnel including two officers who rushed to their rescue also fainted and were evacuated to Port Blair where the 16,900-tonne ship is berthed.

The 37-year-old landing platform helicopter dock was acquired from the United States in June last year. It is now the second-largest naval vessel after the aircraft carrier *INS Virat*.

A board of inquiry has been set up to look into the cause of the accident. Meanwhile, a preliminary enquiry into last month's collision of a naval Kilo-class submarine, *INS Sindhughosh* with a merchant vessel off the Gujarat coast, has narrowed down the cause to negligence—the crew failed to detect the approach of the lumbering merchantman which was fortunately not laden with cargo. by Sandeep Unnikrishnan

Shocker Now

AHMEDABAD Just days after his exhilarating victory in the elections and an unprecedented third tenure as chief minister, the news of the gang rape of a young girl student must have made Narendra Modi's Gujarati *asmita* run for cover and jolted him out of his post-victory stupor. The girl, a Dalit, was raped repeatedly over six months by six of her own teachers at a primary teachers' training college in the state's northern Patan town.

They threatened her that she would not be able



INSTANT JUSTICE: Mob on a rampage in the college to pass her exams if she failed to comply. It was a lone woman teacher in the school who finally took the pregnant girl to a psychiatrist and the case came to light. Girl students and residents of the town thrashed the six teach-

ers—Manish Parmar, Mahendra Prajapati, Ashwin Parmar, Suresh Patel and Atul Patel and Kiran Patel, who were suspended. A call for a bandh by various organisations followed the rampage by the mob in the college.

A shaken Modi has now offered to rehabilitate the victim, announced a compensation of Rs 1 lakh and promised to leave no stone unturned in bringing such culprits to book.

by Uday Mahurkar